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A COMPLETE GUIDE TO THE TAROT

BY EDEN GRAY

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THE MYSTERY OF THE TAROT

The origins of the Tarot are so veiled in the mists of time that it is only natural for myths and legends to surround it. Superstition, flights of fancy, and speculation have added their own patterns to the rich and colorful tapestry of Tarot lore and have only deepened its aura of magic and mystery. Cults have grown up around one or another historical theory, and sometimes their adherents have become fanatical in proclaiming the one and only "truth." But the better-informed investigators retain a certain amount of flexibility—even skepticism—and make no ironclad assertions.

The truest claim we can make is that the Tarot is a symbolic record of human experience. Through deeply rooted mystic powers, the cards accomplish miracles of psychological insight, wise counsel and accurate divination.

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THE TAROT DEFINED

The ancient and mystic pack of cards called the Tarot never fails to evoke the curiosity of the uninitiated. "What are the Tarot cards?" "What makes them so different from our own playing cards?" "Can they really foretell the future?" "Can anyone learn how to read them?"

This book is devoted to answering these and many other questions and to give the reader a knowledge of the Tarot—its history, its links to other occult sciences, and the way it is used to shed light upon the past, the present, and the future.

Everyone agrees that modern playing cards are directly descended from one part of the Tarot—the resemblances between parent and child are too striking to be accidental. In both we find cards numbered one to ten, followed by pictures or "court" cards. And just as the Joker is unnumbered and has no assigned place in our deck, the Fool in the Tarot is also without a number of its own or a pre-ordained position—yet both are ever present in their respective packs.

There are 78 cards in the Tarot, of which 56 (those most like modern cards) are equally divided among four suits—Wands, Cups, Swords, Pentacles—analogueous to our Clubs, Hearts, Spades, and Diamonds. These suit cards are known as the Minor Arcana (*arcana* is the Latin word for secrets). They are followed by 22 cards called the Major Arcana—cards that depict symbolic figures, elements in

nature, the experiences of Man in his spiritual journey, his hopes and fears, his joys and sorrows.

The Major Arcana, as can be seen, bear little resemblance to modern cards. Their illustrations are drawn from the treasurehouse of universal symbols and images, from the legends, myths, philosophies, religions, and magic beliefs of the human race. Undoubtedly the wise men and seers through whom the Tarot is believed to have been transmitted over more than seven centuries were thoroughly versed in the astrological, numerological, and Kabalistic teachings of the ancients, and all these influences are reflected in the cards. The Tarot, nevertheless, remains a unique and independent discipline with its own divinatory powers and its own spiritual content.

Most of us are interested in character analysis, glimpses of the future, solutions to immediate dilemmas—all of which we can seek in the Tarot. But there are also those who will value the Tarot's help in meditation. The student of metaphysics gains remarkable insights into the inner meanings of the cards; the artist, constantly concerned with images and symbols, draws heightened creativity from contemplating the many-dimensional beauty of the cards; the Biblical student finds that the Tarot illuminates many passages in the Old and New Testaments. And since the Tarot is the key that unlocks the wisdom of the ancient philosophers, it reveals its most profound messages to the dedicated scholar and practitioner. (In this it is not unlike the ideographic writing of the Chinese, the hieroglyphics of the Egyptians, the picture writing of the Mayans.)

It is not necessary, however, to understand all the hidden secrets of the cards at first—or even second—glance. When the student is ready, the Tarot will begin to reveal its mysteries. And it is not imperative to “believe in the cards” for them to yield results—you don’t have to take them on blind faith. Eventually you will tap the occult powers of the Tarot, and you will turn to it when dilemmas beset you.

If you consult an experienced “Reader” for help, you become what is called the “Querent,” with an unspoken question you want answered. After laying out the cards in accordance with one of the methods described in this book, the Reader will interpret what the cards are trying to tell you. But you yourself can learn the definitions of the sym-